

JAMES KELLY

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PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Multidisciplinary executive with 20+ years of proven performance across Fortune 500 media operations and bootstrapped startups - building, scaling, and integrating complex organizations in environments defined by ambiguity, speed, and high stakes. Led a \$45M studio operation at Yahoo/Verizon Media through post-acquisition integration, delivering \$10M in annual cost savings while maintaining output across a 300+ person hybrid global team. Co-founded two companies from zero: an internationally ranked immersive experience (Hatch Escapes, #7 globally) and a highly regulated California housing design-build firm (Cassette Systems, current). Navigated complex regulatory environments, built cross-sector stakeholder coalitions, and executed from ambiguous mandates without close oversight. Genuine, demonstrated capacity and interest in AI safety and governance - brings the judgment, operational range, and execution track record to build operational infrastructure through rapid scaling.

CORE COMPETENCIES

- ▶ End-to-End Initiative Ownership
- ▶ Org Design, Change Management & Integration
- ▶ Autonomous Execution in Ambiguous Environments
- ▶ Startup Founding & Large Enterprise Operations
- ▶ Cross-Sector Stakeholder Coordination
- ▶ Strategic Planning & Risk Assessment
- ▶ P&L Ownership & Budget Management (\$45M+)
- ▶ Public-Facing Campaign & Partnership Strategy

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Cassette Systems | *Co-Founder & Chief Operating Officer* | May 2024 – Present

Launched and operated a licensed California modular and manufactured housing design-build firm - a domain requiring rapid mastery of complex regulatory frameworks (HCD, HUD), multi-party stakeholder coordination, and end-to-end operational build-out from scratch.

- Obtained California HCD dealer license and served as dealer-of-record for regulated residential factory-built housing transactions statewide - a legal and operational accountability with no room for error.
- Built all legal, contracting, escrow, and sales documentation infrastructure from zero, navigating a heavily regulated public-interest domain with no prior industry experience.
- Identified an opportunity in an unfamiliar, complex space; defined strategy; built the operational scaffolding; and executed autonomously.

Yahoo / Verizon Media | *Sr. Director, Head of Yahoo Studios* | Nov 2021 – Sep 2023

Led all business operations, finance, HR, and production functions for Yahoo Studios - a \$45M annual operation delivering 60+ hours of original live and VOD content weekly across news, finance, sports, entertainment, and lifestyle verticals.

- P&L ownership for \$45M annual operating budget; led financial reporting cadence directly to CFO team and senior leadership.
- Managed 300+ person hybrid global team across Los Angeles, Silicon Valley, New York, and London - including significant change management through rapid growth and organizational downsizing.
- Oversaw all vendor, contract, and partner relationships across a complex multi-stakeholder production ecosystem.

Verizon Media / RYOT Immersive Studio | *Sr. Director, Strategy & Operations* | Dec 2018 – Nov 2021

Owned strategic planning, business operations, and post-acquisition integration for RYOT - an immersive media and product design agency absorbed into Verizon's media portfolio.

- Led full post-acquisition integration of RYOT into the Verizon Media ecosystem: merged content and product organizations, eliminated redundancies, and delivered \$10M in annual cost savings (~35% reduction) - a high-stakes, ambiguous mandate executed without a previous playbook.
- Built all business processes, strategy, project management, and legal/contracting frameworks for the merged entity.

- Content operation produced two Academy Award-nominated films, a Sundance Directing Award winner, and an Emmy-nominated series.

Verizon Media | *Director, Business Planning & Operations* | Aug 2015 – Nov 2018

- Led content studio integration across AOL, HuffPost, and Yahoo Content organizations during Verizon Media's media rapid growth and acquisition wave.
- Designed and delivered quarterly business analysis and content reviews across Verizon Media's full brand portfolio.
- Oversaw creation of the flagship Verizon 5G Lab content studio in Playa Vista, CA - from concept through operational launch.

Yahoo Studios | *Director, Technology Lead & Music Producer/Engineer* | Jan 2009 – Jul 2015

- Led technology design and build of a flagship NYC broadcast studio facility; opened on schedule in 2012.
- Deployed digital asset management systems migrating all media assets to distributed off-premises storage.
- Produced and engineered thousands of music performances globally, including A-list clients at Skywalker Sound.

Hatch Escapes | *Founder, Designer & Builder* | Jul 2017 – Dec 2019

- Co-founded, designed, and built an escape room company ranked #7 globally in its category - from concept through operation, entirely bootstrapped. Exited cash positive in 2019.
- Demonstrated end-to-end ownership across a complex physical/experiential domain with no prior template.

EDUCATION

BlueDot Impact - Technical AI Safety (in progress) - 2026

BlueDot Impact - Frontier AI Governance (certificate) - 2026

BlueDot Impact - AGI Strategy (certificate) - 2026

BlueDot Impact - Future of AI (certificate) - 2026

UCLA Anderson School of Management - M.B.A. - 2017

Amherst College - B.A., English / Film - 1999